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'Act of war': What happened in Kashmir attack that killed 26 tourists?

The deadliest attack on tourists in Kashmir since 2000 has prompted fears of Indian retaliation against Pakistan.

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Indian security officers patrol in armoured vehicles after gunmen fired indiscriminately at tourists in Pahalgam, southern Indian-administered Kashmir, on April 22, 2025 [Dar Yasin/AP Photo]



By Al Jazeera Staff

23 Apr 2025 | Updated: 6 May 2025 09:40 PM (GMT)

Srinagar, Indian-administered Kashmir — Suspected rebels [killed](#) at least 26 people on Tuesday in the picturesque tourist resort of Pahalgam in the [deadliest such attack](#) in a quarter-century in Indian-administered Kashmir, setting off a chain of tit-for-tat moves by India and Pakistan and raising the spectre of a full-fledged conflict between the nuclear-armed neighbours.

The attack in Kashmir's southern district of Anantnag prompted anger across India. It came amid the peak tourist season as hundreds of thousands of tourists were holidaying in the region, which has been racked by a three-decade armed rebellion.

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Soon after the attack, teams of police and paramilitary troops rushed to the spot to evacuate the wounded tourists and launch a manhunt for the attackers that is continuing two days later.

Indian Home Minister Amit Shah, along with the country's top security brass, rushed to Kashmir, while Prime Minister Narendra Modi cut short a visit to Saudi Arabia to return to New Delhi, where he held a meeting on Wednesday morning to craft India's

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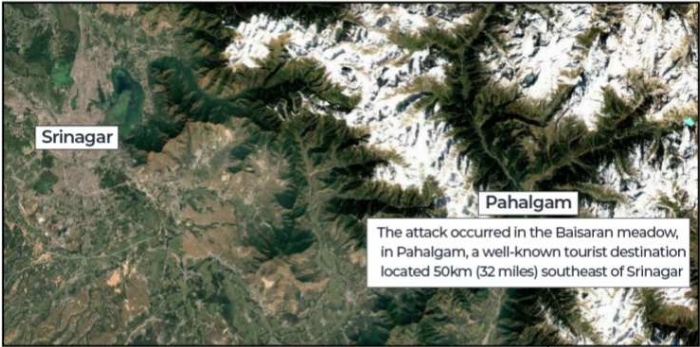
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Gunmen kill at least 26 in Kashmir

Armed men opened fire on a group of tourists in Indian-administered Kashmir, killing at least 26 people, according to Indian police, in one of the deadliest attacks there in recent times.



The attack occurred in the Balsaran meadow, in Pahalgam, a well-known tourist destination located 50km (32 miles) southeast of Srinagar



Indian police officers stand guard at a checkpoint following an attack near Pahalgam in south Kashmir's Anantnag district, on April 22, 2025 [Stringer/Reuters]



Source: Al Jazeera, Google Earth, © OpenStreetMap contributors | April 23, 2025 @AJLabs ALJAZEERA

What happened?

Pahalgam, which means “valley of shepherds” in Kashmiri, is one of the most visited tourist destinations in the region, located about 50km [31 miles] from the main city of Srinagar.

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On Tuesday, witnesses told Al Jazeera that the area was bustling with tourists. At about 2:45pm, a group of armed men in camouflage clothes emerged from a nearby forest, an official said, requesting anonymity to discuss details that security forces have not made public.

The attackers “opened indiscriminate fire at Baisaran meadow, a scenic uphill area accessible only by foot or pony rides,” the official said. Many tourists were caught off-guard as the sudden volley of bullets rang out.

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Simran Chandani, a tourist from Nagpur in the western Indian state of Maharashtra, said she was not sure she would survive the attack.

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recalled, adding that mostly men were fired upon.

She joined the others in trying to escape. “I was taking the name of God and running,” Chandani said.



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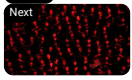
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How many people were killed, and what do we know about them?

At least 26 people have been killed in the attack – all of them men – and more than a dozen others were injured.

The tourists killed were almost all civilians, and an Indian Navy officer from the northern state of Haryana on his honeymoon.

A 68-year-old former banker from Pandurangapuram in the southern state of Andhra Pradesh, who was visiting the region with his wife, was also killed. The deceased also included a realtor from the southern state of Karnataka, an accountant from the eastern state of Odisha, a cement dealer from Uttar Pradesh in the north, and a Gulf returnee from the southern state of Kerala.

One foreign national, a man from Nepal, was among those killed.



Tourists killed in Indian-administered Kashmir attack

Who claimed responsibility for the attack?

A statement issued in the name of [The Resistance Front \(TRF\)](#), which is believed to be an offshoot of the Pakistani-based Lashkar-e-Taiba, claimed responsibility for the attack.

The statement linked the attacks to the thousands of residency permits being handed over to Indian citizens, permitting them to live and work in Kashmir. However, Al Jazeera could not independently confirm the statement’s authenticity.

The Indian government had stripped Kashmir’s semi-autonomous status in 2019.

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Indian officials told Al Jazeera on condition of anonymity that they suspected that four attackers took part in the killings – two of them from Pakistan, and two from Indian-administered Kashmir.



Gunmen kill at least 26 in Indian-administered Kashmir: Police

Have tourists been attacked in the past?

Even amid Kashmir's unrest, direct attacks on tourists have been rare.

In 1995, six foreign tourists were abducted in Pahalgam by the armed group Al-Faran. One was killed, another escaped, and the remaining four were never found.

In 2000, 32 people, including 21 Hindu pilgrims, were killed at Nunwan in Pahalgam.

A year later, 13 people, including 11 pilgrims and two residents, were killed near Sheshnag Lake in the same area. In 2017, eight pilgrims were killed in a shooting incident in the Anantnag district. In June last year, eight Hindu pilgrims were killed in the southern part of Jammu's Kathua when their bus was attacked and fell into a gorge after the driver lost control.

But Tuesday's attack is likely to be the deadliest attack on tourists at least since the 2000 attack in Nunwan.

Overall, Kashmir has not seen death in an attack on this scale since the bombing outside Jammu and Kashmir's state legislature in October 2001, in which 35 people were killed.

The nature and scale of the attack stunned survivors and local politicians.

"We went to Pahalgam, and I was sitting on the chair in the meadow when I heard three shots, which created chaos," said Vinu Bai, a 65-year-old tourist from the western state of Gujarat who was being treated with a bullet injury in the district hospital in Anantnag. "Everyone started running. The bullet in the chaos hit my arm."

"We thought Kashmir was peaceful, we did not know this would happen."

Iltija Mufti, a young politician associated with a local opposition group, said Pahalgam was usually patrolled heavily by Indian security forces. "For an attack like this to happen in a place like Baisaran," she said, "is extremely shocking".

"There's no place for such an attack to take place in our society."

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Indian police officers stand guard near Pahalgam in southern Kashmir where assailants indiscriminately opened fire at tourists, in Indian-administered Kashmir, on Tuesday, April 22, 2025 [Dar Yasin/AP Photo]

How has the Indian government responded?

India announced a series of retaliatory steps on Wednesday after its leaders huddled for hours in the morning, following PM Modi's return from Saudi Arabia.

The steps include:

- Suspending India's participation in the Indus Waters Treaty, a 1960 pact that has governed how India and Pakistan share the waters of the six Indus basin rivers. In theory, India could now try to cut – or entirely stop – the flow of water from these rivers into Pakistan, though that is practically difficult.
- The main land border crossing between the two countries, the Integrated Check Post Attari, or the Attari-Wagah crossing, will be closed with immediate effect, and those who have crossed over with “valid endorsements” have to return through the route before May 1.
- SAARC Visa Exemption Scheme (SVES) visas granted to Pakistanis have been cancelled, and any Pakistani currently visiting India on a SVES visa must leave within 48 hours of the statement issued on Wednesday.
- The military, naval and air advisers in the Pakistani High Commission in New Delhi have a week to leave India, while Indian military, naval and air advisers will be pulled back from the Indian High Commission in Islamabad. Five support staff members will also be pulled from each High Commission.
- The staffing for each High Commission will be reduced from 55 members to 30 through further reductions by May 1.

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In his initial comments on the attack, Modi said on X: “I strongly condemn the terror attack in Pahalgam, Jammu and Kashmir. Condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. I pray that the injured recover at the earliest. All possible assistance is being provided to those affected.”

“Those behind this heinous act will be brought to justice ... they will not be spared!”

Rahul Gandhi, the top opposition leader from the Indian National Congress, slammed the government, urging it to move beyond the “hollow claims” of normalcy in Kashmir since the revocation of Kashmir's special status in 2019.

“The whole country is united against terrorism,” Gandhi said. “Instead of making

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Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Pakistan army chief Asim Munir [File: AP Photo]

How has Pakistan responded?

On Thursday, Pakistan announced its own series of countermeasures in response to India's retaliatory steps.

- It threatened to suspend its participation in the Simla Agreement, a 1972 peace deal signed by the neighbours after India defeated Pakistan in their 1971 war, which also led to the creation of Bangladesh.
- Mirroring India's moves, Pakistan asked all Indians in the country on special SAARC visas to leave.
- Pakistan, too, said it would close the Wagah-Attari border crossing from its end.
- Like India, Pakistan will reduce the strength of its diplomatic mission in New Delhi.
- Pakistan will expel Indian military attaches at its mission in Islamabad.
- Pakistan is suspending all trade with India – including a bar on Indian exports passing through Pakistan to third countries, such as landlocked Afghanistan.
- Pakistan will no longer allow Indian aircraft to fly through its airspace, potentially lengthening their routes in some cases.

Will India retaliate militarily against Pakistan?

The Indian government has not ruled out military action against Pakistan, and experts said a strike of some sort was still a possibility.

“This is an act of war. That's how we are seeing it. It has come just days after that speech by Pakistan's army chief,” Tara Kartha, director at the Centre for Land Warfare Studies (CLAWS), a New Delhi-based think tank, said. Kartha, who was formerly an official at India's National Security Council Secretariat, was referring to last week's address by Pakistani Chief of Army Staff Asim Munir, where he reiterated his support for the two-nation theory that led to India's partition in 1947, and affirmed “difference from Hindus”.

Kartha, speaking on Tuesday, said the actions in Pahalgam match the tone of Munir's “invective-loaded” address on April 16. “Only if Pakistan condemns the attack in the strongest terms and promises action against terrorists in the next 48 hours will a serious crisis be averted.”

Pakistan did respond in the early hours of Wednesday.

“We are concerned at the loss of tourists' lives in an attack in Anantnag district of Indian Illegally Occupied Jammu and Kashmir. We extend our condolences to the near ones of the deceased and wish the injured a speedy recovery,” the Pakistani Ministry of Foreign Affairs said in a statement. India and Pakistan both claim all of Kashmir, while each controls a part of it.

But that statement did little to calm passions in India – as became obvious with New Delhi's retaliatory measures hours later.

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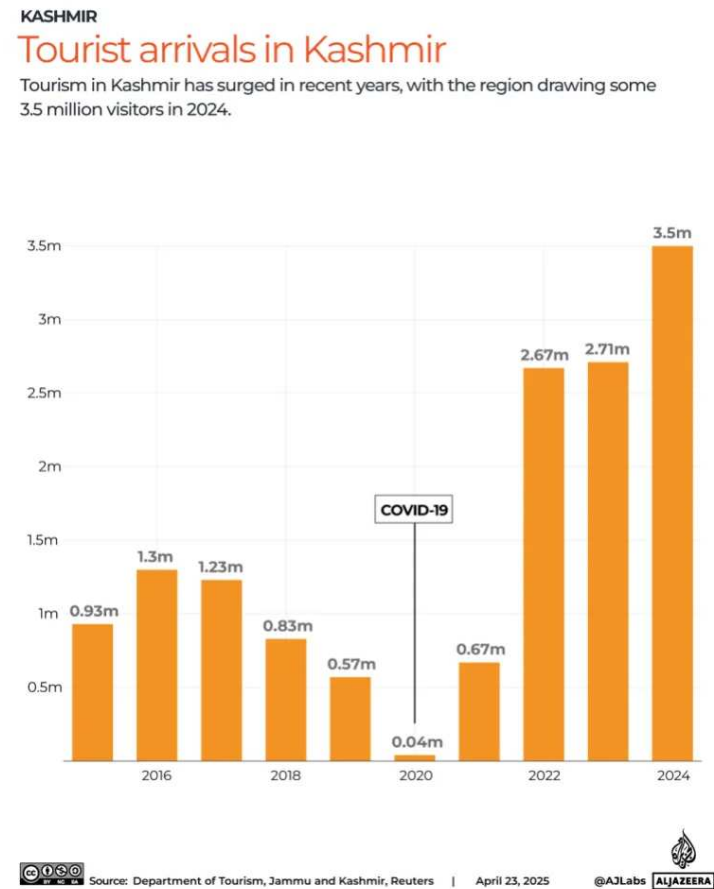
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Yet, while the Modi government is under pressure to act tough against Pakistan, some experts cautioned against an impulsive reaction.

India's relative stability compared with its "highly volatile neighbour" should inform its response, said Saba Naqvi, a veteran political commentator based in New Delhi.

"As for India, most people here think the BJP regime will simply drop bombs there and everything will be avenged," she said, referring to Modi's Hindu majoritarian Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). "But it is not as simple as that."



What does the attack mean for Kashmir?

Kashmiri politicians and civil society have condemned the attack, arguing that such actions hurt residents more than anyone else.

"This is a terrorist act. I don't think I can define it as anything else. Whoever has done it, only wants to harm Kashmiris, our economy and a sense of political stability that had returned to place in the past couple of months," Waheed ur Rehman Para, a Kashmiri legislator from the opposition People's Democratic Party (PDP), told Al Jazeera.

Tourism is an important component of the local economy, contributing nearly 7 percent to its gross domestic product (GDP). A rush of visitors to Kashmir also serves the political messaging of Modi's BJP that it has succeeded in bringing peace and calm to the region.

Yet, even before the Pahalgam attack, things were far from normal in the region. Since 2019, the Indian government has cracked down on political activists and civilians alike, arresting thousands of people under draconian laws that allow it to keep them in detention for lengthy periods without a trial.

Last year in October, Kashmir voted to choose its first elected head after nearly a decade.

Omar Abdullah, a popular provincial politician who campaigned on the promise of reinstating the lost autonomy, clinched a landslide victory in these polls. But his rule has been severely restricted by the new laws of the union territory, with many powers

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the moment,” said Abdul Wahid Malik, a hotelier based in Pahalgam, and former president of the local hoteliers’ guild.

A landslide in Ramban village, a gateway connecting the mountainous Kashmir region with the plains of Jammu, has disrupted traffic in and out of the landlocked valley, pushing airfares higher and making it difficult for fear-stricken tourists to leave the region, following Tuesday’s attack.

After learning that a tourist family was stuck, Malik arranged four rooms for them at his hotel. “We are duty-bound to ensure their safety,” he said. “The attack has devastated us.”

Tourism and business operators in Kashmir called for a shutdown on Wednesday. Other residents also said they were shocked by the incident.

“Kashmir is known for being warm and hospitable,” said Nadiya Farooq, 31, a resident of Srinagar.

“We are devastated by the loss of lives. We want peace and an end to bloodshed. We are grieving.”

How have world leaders reacted?

Leaders from around the world have condemned the attack and have offered condolences.

US President Donald Trump took to X, calling the news from Kashmir “deeply disturbing”.

“The United States stands strong with India against Terrorism. We pray for the souls of those lost and for the recovery of the injured. Prime Minister Modi and the incredible people of India have our full support and deepest sympathies. Our hearts are with you all.”

US Vice President JD Vance, who is visiting India currently, also condemned the attack. “Usha and I extend our condolences to the victims of the devastating terrorist attack in Pahalgam. Over the past few days, we have been overcome with the beauty of this country and its people. Our thoughts and prayers are with them as they mourn this horrific attack,” he said.

United Kingdom Prime Minister Keir Starmer described the attack as “utterly devastating”.

“My thoughts are with those affected, their loved ones, and the people of India,” he posted on X.

Russian President Vladimir Putin denounced the attack, describing it as a “brutal crime” without justification.

The **United Arab Emirates**, in a statement, expressed its strong condemnation “of these criminal acts and its permanent rejection of all forms of violence and terrorism aimed at undermining security and stability in contravention of international law”.

French Ambassador to India Thierry Mathou also expressed solidarity with India in a post on X. “Strong condemnation of the dastardly attack in Jammu & Kashmir. My thoughts are with the victims and their families. France stands in solidarity with India in the fight against terrorism,” he said.

Saudi Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman (MBS), during a bilateral meeting with Modi in Jeddah before the Indian prime minister flew home, condemned the attack and said his country was willing to extend any assistance that India needed.

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